



A CALIFORNIA CHECKLIST

Predator-Proof Your Coop

Why this matters here. In Santa Cruz County a coop will be tested by raccoons, hawks, bobcats, foxes, weasels and ringtails, neighborhood dogs, and rats. Most flock losses are preventable with a few honest upgrades done before you need them. Work through this list once, and you can sleep through the night.

The mesh (the single most important choice)

- ☐ Use half-inch hardware cloth, not chicken wire. Chicken wire keeps chickens in; it does not keep predators out. Raccoons reach and pull through it, and weasels slip through the gaps.
- ☐ Choose 19-gauge or heavier hardware cloth for any opening a predator can reach.
- ☐ Cover every window, vent, and gap. Anything wider than half an inch is an entry point for a weasel or a young rat.

Stop the diggers

- ☐ Add a buried apron: bend hardware cloth outward, extend it 12 to 24 inches out from the base, and bury it a few inches down, or pour a solid floor. Raccoons, foxes, and dogs dig at the base first.
- ☐ Set the run on hardware cloth or a solid base if digging pressure is high.

Lock it like a raccoon is watching (it is)

- ☐ Use two-action latches that require lifting and turning, or a latch plus a clip. Raccoons open simple hooks, slide bolts, and spinning turn-buttons.
- ☐ Secure the nesting box lid and any clean-out door the same way as the main door.

Cover the top

- ☐ Roof or net the run so hawks and owls cannot dive in and raccoons and bobcats cannot climb down. Aerial predators hunt hardest at dawn and dusk.
- ☐ Keep branches and fences pruned back at least several feet from the run so cats and raccoons cannot launch onto it.

Close the night gap

- ☐ Lock birds inside the solid coop every night at dusk, by hand or with an automatic door. The run protects by day; the coop protects by night.
- ☐ Do a quick headcount at lock-up so a missing bird is noticed the same evening.

Remove the dinner bell

- ☐ Bring feeders inside at night and store feed in metal cans with tight lids. Spilled feed draws rats, and rats draw larger predators.
- ☐ Clean up fallen scratch and treats before dark.

Walk the perimeter monthly

- ☐ Check for new digging, chewed corners, rusted mesh, loose staples, and gaps that opened as wood dried and shifted.
- ☐ Fix the smallest gap the day you find it. Predators test the same coop again and again.

Want the whole picture? This checklist is one page of *The California Backyard Flock Starter Guide*, our complete guide to raising chickens, ducks, and geese in coastal California, from choosing birds and building the coop to feeding from the garden and keeping the flock healthy through our wet winters and hot inland summers.



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